

# Eight Pieces of Brocade

??? B?duànj?n: Standing Form

## ORIGINS

The Eight Pieces of Brocade is one of the oldest and most widely practised qigong sets, with roots in the Song dynasty (960–1279 CE). Popular tradition credits the general Yuè Fēi with shaping the form to keep his soldiers strong and resilient; it was later recorded in illustrated form in the nineteenth-century boxing manual of Wáng Zǔyuán. Unlike martial or religious qigong, Bāduànjīn belongs to the lineage of medical qigong, practice designed first and foremost to preserve health.

## WHAT IT IS FOR

Each of the eight pieces addresses a distinct region of the body and a corresponding organ-channel in Chinese medicine. Practised in sequence, the set moves qi and blood through the whole system in a deliberate order: opening the channels, stretching the trunk and limbs, then settling and harmonising what has been raised. The name itself, "brocade", points to the aim: movements woven together into one supple, unbroken piece of silk.

1 → 2 → 3 → 4 → 5 → 6 → 7 → 8

### 1 Two Hands Hold Up the Heavens

雙手托天理三焦 Shuāng Shǒu Tuō Tiān Lǐ Sān Jiāo

TRIPLE BURNER · SAN JIAO

WHOLE-BODY OPENER



#### EXECUTE

Stand with feet shoulder-width apart, knees soft. Interlace the fingers and let them rest before the lower abdomen. On an inhale, turn the palms to face the sky and press them slowly overhead, straightening the arms fully; let the heels lift and the gaze follow the hands upward. On the exhale, release the interlace, sweep the arms out and down, and settle the heels back to the floor.

#### PURPOSE

The Triple Burner has no single physical organ in Western terms; in Chinese medicine it names the pathway that distributes qi and fluid through the upper, middle, and lower cavities of the trunk. This opening piece stretches that entire vertical axis at once, priming circulation through all three chambers before the more targeted pieces that follow.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

Always first. It is the general "key," waking the whole body and setting the unhurried pace and breath rhythm the remaining seven pieces will follow.

### 2 Drawing the Bow to Shoot the Hawk

左右開弓似射鵰 Zuǒ Yǒu Kāi Gōng Sì Shè Diāo

LUNG

CHEST & SHOULDERS



#### EXECUTE

Step into a wide horse stance, knees bent over the toes. Cross the wrists in front of the chest, then extend one hand out to the side as if gripping a bowstring, index finger and thumb open, arm fully straight, while the other elbow draws back sharply toward the ribs, fist closing as though anchoring the string. Gaze follows the extended hand. Return to centre and repeat on the other side.

#### PURPOSE

The wide chest-opening stretch expands the ribcage and diaphragm, deepening the breath and benefiting Lung qi directly. The sustained isometric hold through both arms also builds strength through the upper back and shoulders that habitually round forward.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

Follows the opener by working outward from centre, the Triple Burner has been engaged, now the chest and Lung channel are drawn open on each side in turn.

### 3 Separating Heaven and Earth

調理脾胃須單舉 Tiáolǐ Pí Wèi Xū Dān Jǔ

SPLEEN · STOMACH

TORSO STRETCH



#### EXECUTE

Stand naturally. On an inhale, press one palm up overhead as though supporting the sky, while the opposite palm presses down toward the earth beside the hip, fingers pointing forward. Let the two opposing pressures stretch the whole side of the torso long. Exhale to release both hands back to the sides, then reverse the hands and repeat.

#### PURPOSE

The opposite-direction stretch through the trunk gently massages the abdominal cavity. In Chinese medicine this is said to harmonise Spleen and Stomach, the Spleen governs the transformation and transport of food into usable qi and blood, while the Stomach governs its downward movement; this piece supports both functions and is traditionally associated with digestion.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

Where the second piece opened the chest laterally, this piece opens the torso vertically along one side at a time, working inward to the digestive organs before the form moves to the neck and spine.

### 4 The Wise Owl Gazes Backward

五勞七傷往後瞧 Wǔ Láo Qī Shāng Wǎng Hòu Qiào

NECK · NERVOUS SYSTEM

GENERAL FATIGUE



#### EXECUTE

Stand relaxed, hands resting lightly at the hips or thighs. Keeping the torso still and facing forward, slowly rotate the head and neck to gaze back over one shoulder as far as is comfortable, without forcing. Hold briefly, return to centre, then turn to the other side.

#### PURPOSE

The line in the classical verse refers to "the five strains and seven injuries", the traditional catalogue of harm caused by prolonged overuse: too much sitting, standing, walking, lying down, or looking. This piece targets the accumulated tension that gathers in the neck and upper spine from exactly this kind of overwork, and is said to clear stagnation from the nervous system broadly rather than one organ specifically.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

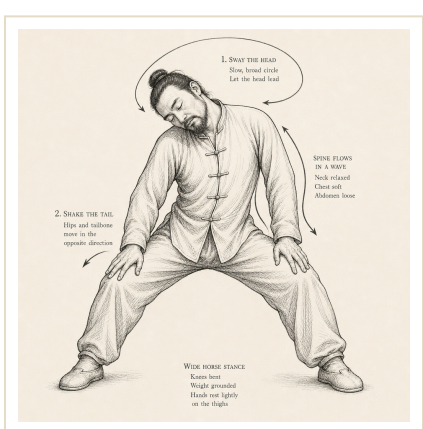
A turning point in the set: having opened the trunk and limbs, attention now moves to the neck and spine before the following two pieces work the heart and kidneys along the length of the back.

### 5 Sway the Head and Shake the Tail

搖頭擺尾去心火 Yáo Tóu Bǎi Wěi Qù Xīn Huǒ

HEART

COOLING / CALMING



#### EXECUTE

Take a wide horse stance and rest the hands lightly on the thighs, well above the knees. Lean the torso forward and let the head lead a broad, slow circular sway, down and across, drawing an arc, while the hips and tailbone counter-sway in the opposite direction beneath it. Reverse the circle. Move slowly; there is no force in this piece, only a wide, gentle spiral.

#### PURPOSE

The verse names its aim outright: "sway the head and shake the tail to dispel heart fire." In Chinese medicine, an excess of Heart fire is associated with agitation, restlessness, and disturbed sleep. The wide spinal spiral is said to draw this excess heat downward and out through the extremities, leaving the mind cooler and calmer.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

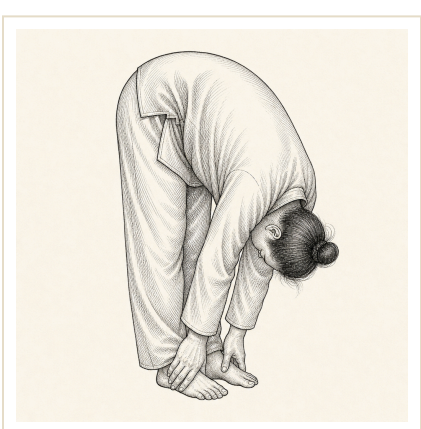
The most overtly circular, "loosening" piece in the set, a release valve between the structural neck work before it and the more effortful kidney and liver pieces that follow.

### 6 Two Hands Hold the Feet

兩手攀足固腎腰 Liǎng Shǒu Pān Zú Gù Shèn Yāo

KIDNEY

LOWER BACK · BLADDER CHANNEL



#### EXECUTE

Stand with feet shoulder-width apart. Inhale as the arms sweep up overhead and the back arches gently backward. Exhale as the torso folds forward from the hips, hands sliding down the legs toward the ankles or feet, knees may soften slightly rather than locking. Inhale to rise back up, sweeping the hands up along the front of the body to standing.

#### PURPOSE

The forward fold lengthens the Bladder channel, which runs the full length of the back from the eyes to the little toe, and in doing so is said to strengthen the Kidneys, the organ system that in Chinese medicine stores j?ng, foundational vital essence, and governs the lower back and knees.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

The deepest spinal stretch of the set, placed after the loosening fifth piece so the back is already warm and pliable, and before the more forceful, standing-strength pieces that close the form.

### 7 Clench the Fists and Glare Fiercely

攢拳怒目增氣力 Zuǎn Quán Nù Mù Zēng Qìlì

LIVER

STRENGTH · SINEWS



#### EXECUTE

Sink into a low, wide horse stance, both fists chambered at the waist. Punch one fist straight forward with real intent, gripping it tightly at full extension while the eyes widen and focus sharply along the punching arm, the "glare" of the title. Withdraw with control and repeat on the other side, keeping the stance low throughout.

#### PURPOSE

The forceful punch and wide-eyed focus both correspond to the Liver in Chinese medicine, which is said to open into the eyes and to govern the sinews and tendons. Practised with genuine gripping intent, the piece is traditionally held to move stagnant Liver qi and build both physical strength and a settled, assertive vitality.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

The most externally forceful piece, deliberately placed near the end, the body has been opened and lengthened, and can now safely generate real power through it.

### 8 Bouncing on the Toes

背後七顛百病消 Bèi Hòu Qī Diǎn Bǎi Bìng Xiāo

WHOLE BODY

CLOSING · INTEGRATION



#### EXECUTE

Stand with feet together or nearly so, arms relaxed at the sides. Inhale slowly as the heels rise, coming up onto the balls of the feet. Exhale and let the heels drop, releasing them to the floor with a soft, gentle bounce rather than a hard landing. Repeat seven or more times, keeping the spine long throughout.

#### PURPOSE

The closing verse says simply that this piece "dispels a hundred illnesses." Rather than targeting one organ, its role is to settle: the gentle jolt through the skeleton is traditionally said to smooth and evenly redistribute the qi that the previous seven pieces have raised and moved, so that nothing is left stirred up or unresolved.

#### IN THE SEQUENCE

Always last. Where the first piece opened the whole body, this piece closes it, a brief, rhythmic settling before returning to quiet standing.

## PRACTICE NOTES

### BEGINNING & ENDING

- Begin and end each session standing quietly in wújǐ, feet parallel, weight centred, breath settling, before the first piece and after the last.
- Each piece is traditionally repeated 6–8 times per side (or per full cycle for symmetrical pieces).
- Move at the pace of the breath, not the reverse, let the breath set the timing of every movement.

### BREATH & INTENTION

- As a rule, expansion and rising movements pair with the inhale, and folding, pressing, or descending movements pair with the exhale.
- The mind (yì) leads gently at each hand or gaze point, attention placed lightly, never strained, on where the movement is going.

### SUITABLE FOR

- Bāduànjīn is considered one of the gentlest entry points into qigong practice and is appropriate for most students regardless of prior experience.
- As with any physical practice, students with acute injury, recent surgery, or cardiovascular concerns should modify range of motion and consult their own physician as needed.